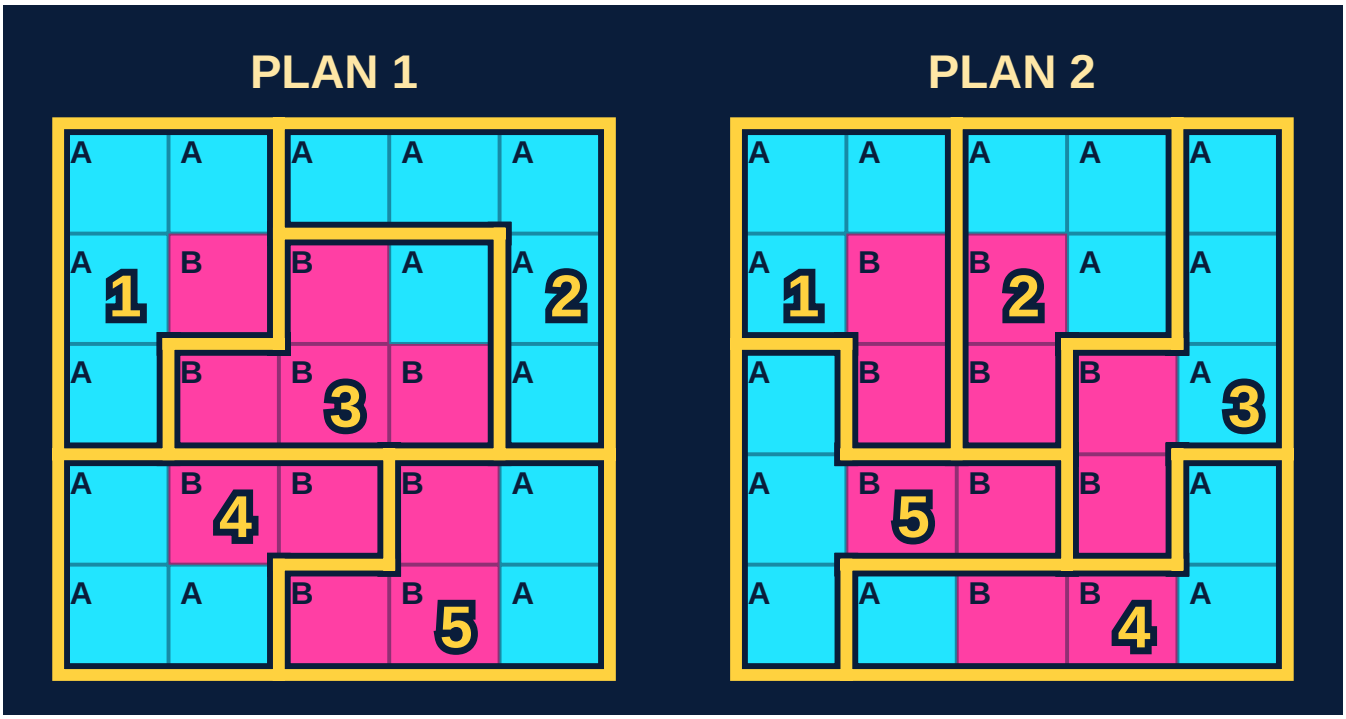
Drawing the Lines

AP Human Geography · Unit 4 · Two stimuli (like Question 3) · 7 points · Teacher key · GeoArcade FRQ Tutor

Westmoor, a fictional U.S. state, has 25 voting precincts with equal populations and 5 seats in the U.S. House of Representatives. After the census, mapmakers proposed two plans for grouping those precincts into 5 districts, using the same voters and votes.

Stimulus 1: Two District Plans for Westmoor



A = precinct won by Party A B = precinct won by Party B District border 1–5 = district number

Fictional state created for practice. Simplified: all 25 precincts have equal populations, and a party wins a district by winning at least 3 of its 5 precincts.

Stimulus 2: Election Results in Westmoor Under Each Plan

Result	Party A	Party B
Statewide vote share	60%	40%
Precincts won (of 25)	15	10
Districts won under Plan 1 (of 5)	3	2
Percent of seats under Plan 1	60%	40%
Districts won under Plan 2 (of 5)	5	0
Percent of seats under Plan 2	100%	0%

Fictional data created for practice. Simplified: equal-population precincts, and the same statewide vote under both plans. Remember: label each part, and write Describe and Explain parts as T1- (your reason in general words), E2- (the specific proof), A3- (why it matters).

A. Using Stimulus 1, identify the gerrymandering technique used to draw the district boundaries in Plan 2. IDENTIFY

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ANY ONE OF THESE:

- Names cracking
- Describes cracking: Party B's voters split across districts so they're outnumbered

MODEL ANSWER

Plan 2 uses cracking: Party B's voters are split across all five districts so they are outnumbered in every one.

Common mistake: "Packing, because Party A packed the districts with its own voters." That mixes up the terms. Packing crowds the OTHER party's voters together. Plan 2 does the opposite: it spreads Party B's voters out so they lose everywhere.

Why the model works: It names the right term (cracking) and shows how it works: Party B's voters are split up and outnumbered everywhere.

B. Using Stimulus 1, describe how the district boundaries in Plan 2 divide Party B's voters. DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Describes the split: about 2 Party B precincts in each district
- Describes the result: Party B is outnumbered in every district

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Plan 2's district lines split Party B's cluster of voters into five pieces.

E2- Party B's 10 precincts are bunched in the center and south, but the lines slice that cluster like a pizza, so each district gets exactly 2 Party B precincts and 3 Party A precincts.

A3- Because Party B has only 2 of 5 precincts in every district, it is outnumbered 3 to 2 everywhere and cannot win a single district.

Common mistake: "Plan 2 divides Party B's voters into different districts." That just repeats the question. Describe HOW they're divided (2 Party B precincts in each district) and what that does (Party B is outnumbered everywhere).

Why the model works: It describes the split, gives map evidence (2 Party B precincts per district), and describes the result (outnumbered everywhere).

C. Explain why the boundaries of congressional districts in the United States are redrawn every ten years. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names the census as the trigger
- Explains the chain: seats shift between states, so lines are redrawn to keep districts equal

MODEL ANSWER

T1- District lines are redrawn every ten years because the U.S. Census counts the population every ten years, and populations shift.
E2- After each census, the House's 435 seats are reapportioned among the states by population; after 2020, Texas gained two seats and New York lost one.
A3- Because a state's population and seat count can change, it must redraw its districts (redistricting) so each has about the same number of people: one person, one vote.

Common mistake: "Because politicians want to change the lines to help their party win." That's why people GERRYMANDER, not why lines are redrawn every ten years. The required reason is the census and shifting population.

Why the model works: It names the trigger (the census), explains reapportionment with real examples, and explains why lines must change (equal population).

D. Using both stimuli, explain how Plan 2 produces an election result that does not match the statewide vote. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Uses Stimulus 2: votes vs. seats (Party B: 40% of votes, 0% of seats)
- Uses Stimulus 1 for the cause: Party B has only 2 of 5 precincts in each district

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Plan 2 gives Party A every seat because it cracks Party B's voters so they are a minority in every district.
E2- Stimulus 2 shows Party B won 40% of the statewide vote but 0% of the seats under Plan 2, and Stimulus 1 shows why: each Plan 2 district has exactly 2 Party B precincts and 3 Party A precincts.
A3- Because Party B is outnumbered 3 to 2 in all five districts, its votes are wasted everywhere, so Party A turns 60% of the vote into 100% of the seats.

Common mistake: "Party A got 60% of the vote but won 100% of the seats." True, but it only restates Stimulus 2. The question asks HOW, so add Stimulus 1: Party B has only 2 of 5 precincts in every district.

Why the model works: It uses BOTH stimuli: the table for the mismatch (40% of votes, 0% of seats) and the map for the cause (2 of 5 precincts per district).

E. Using Stimulus 2, explain ONE effect that a districting plan like Plan 2 could have on voters or on political representation. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Uses Stimulus 2: Party B wins 40% of the vote but 0 seats
- Explains an effect: no representation, wasted votes, lower turnout, safe seats, or polarization

MODEL ANSWER

T1- One effect of a plan like Plan 2 is that a large group of voters ends up with no representation, which can lower voter turnout.
E2- Stimulus 2 shows Party B won 40% of the statewide vote but 0% of the seats under Plan 2, so four in ten voters have no representative from the party they chose.
A3- Because Party B's voters lose in every district no matter how many show up, many may feel their votes don't count and stop voting.

Common mistake: "Gerrymandering is unfair to Party B." Too vague. It doesn't use the table or name an effect. Say what happens: Party B gets 40% of the vote but 0% of the seats, so its voters may stop voting.

Why the model works: It quotes Stimulus 2 (40% of votes, 0% of seats), names a specific effect (lower turnout), and explains how Plan 2 causes it.

F. Explain ONE way that an independent redistricting commission OR a compactness requirement could reduce gerrymandering like the one in Plan 2. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names the method: an independent commission or a compactness rule
- Explains how: takes line-drawing away from politicians who benefit, or bans odd shapes that split up voters

MODEL ANSWER

T1- An independent redistricting commission could reduce gerrymandering by taking map-drawing away from politicians.
E2- Arizona, Colorado, and Michigan created commissions of citizens from both major parties plus independents, who draw the maps instead of the state legislature.
A3- Because these mapmakers aren't trying to keep their own party in power, they have less reason to crack one party's voters the way Plan 2 cracks Party B.

Common mistake: "An independent commission would make redistricting fair." It names a fix but never explains HOW. Add the mechanism: the commission takes map-drawing away from politicians who benefit from cracking the other party's voters.

Why the model works: It names one fix, gives real examples, and explains how it reduces cracking (the mapmakers don't benefit from it).

G. Explain how district boundaries like those in Plan 2 could act as a centrifugal force in a country. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Describes a divisive reaction: distrust, anger, feeling unrepresented, or protest
- Connects it to a centrifugal force: it divides people or weakens unity and loyalty

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Unfair district boundaries like Plan 2's can act as a centrifugal force because they make a large group of citizens lose trust in their government.
E2- Under Plan 2, Party B's voters cast 40% of the votes but win no seats, so they may feel cheated and protest or refuse to accept election results.
A3- When many citizens believe the system is rigged, tension between groups grows and loyalty to the government weakens, which pulls the country apart.

Common mistake: "A centrifugal force is something that divides a country." A correct definition, but it never connects to Plan 2. Explain how unfair districts make voters lose trust in government, and how that divides the country.

Why the model works: It explains the reaction (lost trust), uses the scenario (40% of the votes, no seats), and connects it to the definition (weaker loyalty).

Scoring guide written for the GeoArcade FRQ Tutor. Award each part independently, 1 point each.